followed through with his threat not to continue in the post of chairman after he turned seventy-five, even if a successor was not in place. The ‘committee’s view’ that was recorded as a part of the minutes flags several drawbacks in Mistry’s suitability. The findings read as follows:

> He would need support and an advisory council to support him.
>
> He should learn to delegate.
>
> He should learn the complexities of the Group.
>
> Relies on the buzzword of ‘strategy’ too much.
>
> Should be counselled on risk-taking.
>
> Seen as a bright possibility but lacking in experience. A council for CM [Cyrus Mistry] would be a necessity.
>
> He would need the backing of Mr RNT for a period of time to gain acceptability.

The meeting also expressed concern about his foreign citizenship.

In the next meeting, on 4 June 2011, a decision was taken to meet Mistry again as the committee concluded that when it had met him last, it had only ‘informally on the spur of the moment interviewed him’. The committee also did not have Mistry’s CV at the time. By way of abundant caution, it clarified that whoever may be finally selected as chairman, Tata Sons, ‘the Chairman of the Trusts would continue to be Mr RNT. This position was not negotiable.’ It said that ‘there is hardly likely to be a person who could have the same breadth of knowledge, the same stature both in India and abroad, the same moral authority as Mr RNT’. It also recommended the creation of a ‘cabinet committee of experts’ drawn from the fields of human resources, finance and technical to assist the new chairman to find his feet.

On 6 August 2011, the committee (sans Mistry) met Anshu Jain of Deutsche Bank. On the same day, it was resolved to invite Mistry for a formal interaction. The proceedings outlined what his CV and the details to be submitted before the committee should contain. It said that his ‘formal CV which should contain a description of his organization, its pluses and minuses, and how he could be [at] arm’s length if selected, should be circulated to all members’.

In the meantime, however, pressure was mounting on the committee. It had by now deliberated for nearly twelve months without success. This made Ratan uneasy. He reiterated that he would not continue a day longer than 28 December 2012, when he would ‘walk out’—a decision he would come to rue later. He now says that he regrets having issued an ultimatum